Rose nodded. “Are you strong enough to walk a little more?”

“Yes, we can. We came with others,” the man with the blanket said, pointing in the direction of the road out of town. “They need a doctor.”

“Others?” Léa didn’t see anyone behind them.

“A few kilometers back. They couldn’t walk anymore. One is badly injured. We went ahead to get a doctor.”

“How many?” Léa asked.

“Ten. We were all camping on the banks of the Elbe River. We’d already lost our homes when the Russians came into Silesia. We thought we’d be safe in Dresden.” He shook his head.

“You’re safe now,” Léa said. “The doctor is at the sick bay, just up the road.” She turned to Rose. “Take them there and I’ll go look for the others.”

The guard stepped forward. “I’ll come with you, Fräulein Cotillard, to help bring the others. Let’s take the mule with the cart.”

Rose could see that the scales had been lifted from the guard’s eyes. Was it the first time he’d seen his own people become refugees? If the lack of food, coal and medicine hadn’t been enough to show him that the end of the war was coming, and Germany would lose, then the bombing of Dresden would.

The injured man and Rose, with the younger women, made their way along the street. The sun was now up. People opened their curtains. When they reached the sick bay, Rose turned back and saw in the distance a massive plume of smoke gathered in the sky. She gasped. “Could that be from the fires at Dresden?”

“Yes.” The man crossed himself.

Rose drew in a breath, saying a little prayer, as her mother would have, for all those souls struggling to stay alive in a burning city.

A grave look crossed Josef’s face as he saw Rose enter with the three patients.

“What happened?” he asked, helping to bring the patients over to the empty beds.

“Dresden was bombed. These people walked here.”

“We came in a group,” the man said as Josef examined his face.

Rose told him that Léa and the night guard had gone with the donkey cart to find the others in the forest who couldn’t walk any farther. “I’ll find André, tell him, then I’ll come back to help.”